PRELIMINARY EXPERT RESEARCH MEMORANDUM / REVIEW COPY

Hart Davis Hart Auction Co. v. Spicer

The public docket does not make the complaint text or a trade-secret designation available in this bounded review. Hart Davis Hart publicly describes itself as a wine auction house and online retailer; public company materials identify auction, consignment, customer-service, and technology functions. The issue map accordingly addresses possible auction-platform, consignment/customer-information, digital pricing, bidding-history, and access-control questions without characterizing any particular information as a claimed secret.

Independent preliminary research based on public information.

FILED	FORUM	DOCKET	MATTER
2026-08-25	U.S. District Court for the Northern District of Illinois	1:26-cv-10274	Defend Trade Secrets Act

Prepared 2026-08-27. No attorney or expert contacted. Availability, interest, compensation, and conflicts not checked.

01 / MATTER VERIFICATION AND ASSESSMENT

Public filing, likely recipient, and technical frame

CAPTION	Hart Davis Hart Auction Co. LLC et al. v. Spicer
FORUM / DOCKET	U.S. District Court for the Northern District of Illinois / 1:26-cv-10274
FILED / TYPE	2026-08-25 / Defend Trade Secrets Act
PUBLIC DOCKET	Open docket

VERIFIED PUBLIC RECORD

The public docket identifies the two Hart Davis Hart entities as plaintiffs, Moriah Spicer as defendant, docket number 1:26-cv-10274, the Northern District of Illinois, an August 25, 2026 filing date, a Defend Trade Secrets Act case type, and Steven L. Brenneman as the attorney who filed the complaint and appearance for plaintiffs.

LIKELY RESEARCH PURCHASER

Steven L. Brenneman - Outside counsel, Fox Swibel Levin & Carroll LLP. The public docket says Brenneman filed the complaint and entered an appearance for both plaintiffs. Treating the filing attorney as a possible purchaser of expert-search research is an analytical inference, not a verified purchasing decision.

sbrenneman@foxswibel.com - publicly printed in the linked professional source; not inferred.

TECHNICAL FRAME

The public docket does not make the complaint text or a trade-secret designation available in this bounded review. Hart Davis Hart publicly describes itself as a wine auction house and online retailer; public company materials identify auction, consignment, customer-service, and technology functions. The issue map accordingly addresses possible auction-platform, consignment/customer-information, digital pricing, bidding-history, and access-control questions without characterizing any particular information as a claimed secret.

Secondary-source limitation: This is preliminary public-source research. The complaint, any motion papers, the trade-secret identification, and discovery must control what information is actually alleged to be secret, how it was accessed, and what system or records are relevant. Open public synopsis

Questions likely to require expert input

This issue map is a research plan, not a legal conclusion. The filed complaint, patent exhibits, intrinsic record, and discovery must control.

01 Technical definition of the alleged information

Does the operative pleading identify particular auction-platform logic, valuation or pricing models, bidder and consignment datasets, customer relationship records, workflow rules, system architecture, or access credentials, and what technical boundary separates those materials from ordinary industry knowledge?

Potential evidence: Complaint and trade-secret identification; product and system specifications; source repositories; databases and schemas; CRM/auction-platform exports; access-control records; policy documents; and relevant employee agreements.

02 Auction and pricing-system provenance

Which system generated, stored, transformed, or exposed bidding, price, lot, customer, and consignment data, and can metadata and logs establish who accessed or exported which records and when?

Potential evidence: Application audit logs; cloud, database, CRM, and identity-provider logs; exports; API logs; device images; version history; backup records; and native data dictionaries.

03 Whether claimed methods are independently reproducible

Could the relevant auction workflows, pricing analytics, customer segmentation, or valuation outputs be independently developed from public auction results, ordinary wine-market knowledge, lawful customer interactions, and commercially available e-commerce/CRM systems?

Potential evidence: Public auction catalogs and results; software documentation; comparable marketplace workflows; independent-development records; model inputs; training material; and reproducible data-analysis tests.

04 Data provenance, overlap, and derivation

Do the disputed datasets share records, fields, transformations, identifiers, error patterns, timestamps, or other forensic indicia with source data, or are they explainable by independent collection and ordinary commercial sources?

Potential evidence: Native databases and exports; record-level comparisons; hash and similarity analyses; ETL scripts; query history; vendor data licenses; public data captures; and data-lineage documentation.

Questions likely to require expert input

05 Platform controls and reasonable secrecy measures

What authentication, authorization, device-management, retention, monitoring, segmentation, and export controls governed the particular records or systems at issue, and how did those controls operate at the relevant time?

Potential evidence: Identity and access-management configuration; role matrices; SSO logs; endpoint-management records; NDAs; security policies; audit trails; and incident-response materials.

06 Technical causation and damages inputs

If technical use is established, what measurable role did it play in auction conversion, seller acquisition, pricing, bidding participation, revenue, or operating efficiency, and what alternative explanations must be separated?

Potential evidence: Event-level platform data; sales and consignment records; cohort analyses; experiment or model documentation; communications; comparable periods; and marketplace benchmarks.

Candidates 1-2 for further diligence

Ranked for preliminary research priority based on subject-matter fit, relevant public work, testimony, and visible diligence burden. This is not a retention recommendation.

01 Ravi Bapna

Curtis L. Carlson Chair Professor in Business Analytics and Information Systems, University of Minnesota Carlson School of Management

TECHNICAL FIT

Online auctions, business analytics, big data, machine learning, online strategies, and monetization directly fit auction-platform data, bidding behavior, and technical-causation questions.

RELEVANT WORK

His official profile lists online auctions and economics of IT among his expertise and identifies research in analytics, AI/ML, digital transformation, social media, and information systems.

PUBLIC LITIGATION EXPERIENCE

No candidate-specific expert report, declaration, deposition, or trial testimony was located in the bounded public-source review.

POINTS FOR FURTHER DILIGENCE

The filing has not publicly identified the alleged secret, so auction analytics may be too specific if the dispute is instead about nontechnical relationship information.

Source 1 | Source 2

Draft email | ravibapna@umn.edu | public email source

02 Alok Gupta

Curtis L. Carlson Chair in Information Management, University of Minnesota Carlson School of Management

TECHNICAL FIT

Online auctions, information security, digital rights management, real-time mechanisms, and information economics are relevant to platform operation, data controls, and auction-process comparison.

RELEVANT WORK

His official profile lists online auctions and information security; a University of Minnesota technology page identifies his work on real-time bidder feedback in continuous combinatorial auctions.

PUBLIC LITIGATION EXPERIENCE

No candidate-specific expert report, declaration, deposition, or trial testimony was located in the bounded public-source review.

POINTS FOR FURTHER DILIGENCE

The case may ultimately call for wine-industry evidence or digital-forensics expertise beyond market-mechanism analysis.

Source 1 | Source 2

Draft email | agupta@umn.edu | public email source

Candidates 3-4 for further diligence

03 Michael P. Wellman

Lynn A. Conway Collegiate Professor of Computer Science and Engineering, University of Michigan

TECHNICAL FIT

Computational economics, strategic multi-agent systems, machine learning, and information-security applications align with algorithmic auction, bidding, and platform-behavior questions.

RELEVANT WORK

Michigan describes his research as combining economics and computer science to analyze complex interacting-agent systems, including work in financial markets and information security.

PUBLIC LITIGATION EXPERIENCE

No candidate-specific expert report, declaration, deposition, or trial testimony was located in the bounded public-source review.

POINTS FOR FURTHER DILIGENCE

A computational-market specialist may require a complementary forensic data expert if the disputed issue is raw database extraction or access logging.

Source 1 | Source 2

Draft email | wellman@umich.edu | public email source

04 Anindya Ghose

Heinz Riehl Professor of Business, New York University Stern School of Business

TECHNICAL FIT

Digital platforms, electronic commerce, data privacy, business analytics, and online consumer behavior are relevant to customer-data, platform analytics, and technical damages questions.

RELEVANT WORK

NYU identifies research interests including digital advertising and marketing, data privacy, antitrust in technology, AI, digital platforms, and electronic commerce.

PUBLIC LITIGATION EXPERIENCE

No candidate-specific expert report, declaration, deposition, or trial testimony was located in the bounded public-source review.

POINTS FOR FURTHER DILIGENCE

Digital-market analysis may be secondary if the alleged secret turns out to be a narrow operational workflow or an employee relationship list rather than platform data.

Source 1

Draft email | ag122@stern.nyu.edu | public email source

Candidates 5-6 for further diligence

05 Kartik Hosanagar

John C. Hower Professor of Technology and Digital Business, The Wharton School, University of Pennsylvania

TECHNICAL FIT

E-commerce, digital media, internet marketing, AI, network effects, and technology-platform development fit issues involving an online marketplace, customer data, and platform functionality.

RELEVANT WORK

Wharton identifies e-commerce, digital media, and AI among his research interests and reports that he co-founded Yodle and developed its core IP.

PUBLIC LITIGATION EXPERIENCE

No candidate-specific expert report, declaration, deposition, or trial testimony was located in the bounded public-source review.

POINTS FOR FURTHER DILIGENCE

Platform and marketing expertise may not resolve specialized digital-forensic questions without a separate forensic examiner.

Source 1 | Source 2

Draft email | kartikh@wharton.upenn.edu | public email source

06 Yiling Chen

Gordon McKay Professor of Computer Science, Harvard University

TECHNICAL FIT

Information elicitation, aggregation, information design, algorithmic game theory, multi-agent systems, and incentive-aware machine learning fit auction mechanism and bidding-information questions.

RELEVANT WORK

Her Harvard profile identifies research in information elicitation and aggregation, information design, algorithmic game theory, multi-agent systems, and incentive-aware machine learning.

PUBLIC LITIGATION EXPERIENCE

No candidate-specific expert report, declaration, deposition, or trial testimony was located in the bounded public-source review.

POINTS FOR FURTHER DILIGENCE

Her theoretical and computational focus may be more useful for mechanism questions than practical data-lineage reconstruction.

Source 1 | Source 2

Draft email | yiling@seas.harvard.edu | public email source

Candidates 7-8 for further diligence

07 Eric Budish

Paul G. McDermott Professor of Economics and Entrepreneurship, University of Chicago Booth School of Business

TECHNICAL FIT

Market design, auctions, incentives, and market-mechanism evaluation fit questions about the architecture and economic effects of an auction process.

RELEVANT WORK

Chicago Booth describes his research in market design, including frequent batch auctions and market designs for online marketplaces and event tickets.

PUBLIC LITIGATION EXPERIENCE

No candidate-specific expert report, declaration, deposition, or trial testimony was located in the bounded public-source review.

POINTS FOR FURTHER DILIGENCE

His work is highly senior and market-design focused; it may be less suited to granular e-discovery or implementation-level system forensics.

Source 1 | Source 2

Draft email | eric.budish@chicagobooth.edu | public email source

08 Katia Sycara

Edward Fredkin Research Professor and Associate Director of Faculty, Carnegie Mellon University Robotics Institute

TECHNICAL FIT

Multi-agent systems, game-theoretic techniques, e-commerce, and auction systems can support analysis of automated bidding, marketplace coordination, and platform decision logic.

RELEVANT WORK

Carnegie Mellon describes her work in multi-agent systems and autonomous coordination; her public materials include e-commerce-auction projects and a BiddingBot system for multiple online auction sites.

PUBLIC LITIGATION EXPERIENCE

No candidate-specific expert report, declaration, deposition, or trial testimony was located in the bounded public-source review.

POINTS FOR FURTHER DILIGENCE

Her present research emphasizes robotics and multi-agent systems; the relation to the particular HDH technology must be confirmed after the complaint is available.

Source 1 | Source 2 | Source 3

Draft email | katia@cs.cmu.edu | public email source

Candidates 9-10 for further diligence

09 Dinesh K. Gauri

Chair and Melvin H. Baker Professor of Marketing, University at Buffalo School of Management

TECHNICAL FIT

Pricing, retail promotions, shopper and commerce marketing, revenue management, and customer loyalty fit technical damages and customer-data questions connected to an online auction/retail operation.

RELEVANT WORK

Buffalo identifies research in retail promotions, shopper and commerce marketing, pricing, social media, revenue management, and omnichannel retailing.

PUBLIC LITIGATION EXPERIENCE

No candidate-specific expert report, declaration, deposition, or trial testimony was located in the bounded public-source review.

POINTS FOR FURTHER DILIGENCE

Retail/marketing orientation may not fit an alleged software, security, or algorithm trade secret without a complementary systems expert.

Source 1 | Source 2

Draft email | dkgauri@buffalo.edu | public email source

10 Prasanna (Sonny) Tambe

Professor of Operations, Information and Decisions and Co-Director of Wharton Human-AI Research, The Wharton School, University of Pennsylvania

TECHNICAL FIT

Economics of information-technology labor, AI, algorithms, and Internet-scale data supports questions concerning employee access, independent development, data use, and the value of digital capabilities.

RELEVANT WORK

Wharton describes research using Internet-scale data to analyze technical labor markets, skills, software developers, algorithms, and AI's effects on work.

PUBLIC LITIGATION EXPERIENCE

No candidate-specific expert report, declaration, deposition, or trial testimony was located in the bounded public-source review.

POINTS FOR FURTHER DILIGENCE

His labor-market focus may be less direct if the operative claim centers on auction mechanics rather than employee access and independent development.

Source 1 | Source 2

Draft email | tambe@wharton.upenn.edu | public email source

Preliminary candidates; no conflicts or availability determination

- Run party, affiliate, counsel, inventor, funder, and technology conflicts.

- Confirm testimony history, exclusions, compensation, publications, patents, and deposition performance.

- Investigate licensing, grants, consulting, commercial interests, and prior technical positions.

- Confirm role fit, availability, and interest only after counsel authorizes outreach.

ONGOING MATTER-SPECIFIC RESEARCH

Flint Witness Research works in the post-filing window, turning pleadings and public technical records into issue maps, researched candidate slates, and diligence starting points as the case develops.

Schedule a 15-minute conversation

CORE SOURCES

Public docket: https://dockets.justia.com/docket/illinois/ilndce/1%3A2026cv10274/506641

Public professional email source: https://foxswibel.com/attorney/steven-l-brenneman/

Public technical context source: https://www.hdhwine.com/ and https://hdhauctions.com/wp-content/uploads/2024/03/2402_catalog.pdf

LIMITATIONS

This is preliminary public-source research. The complaint, any motion papers, the trade-secret identification, and discovery must control what information is actually alleged to be secret, how it was accessed, and what system or records are relevant.

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